

Bluff

YOUR WAY THROUGH

GPU Terminology

Not all of us can afford multi-GPU solutions. If you find yourself being left out of conversations involving GPUs or want to fool your friends into believing that you're a GPU-geek, here's something that might help:

HDR: High Dynamic Range in 3D gaming is the collective name given to a set of techniques used to create a greater variation between intensity levels of light. HDRs will play a greater role in upcoming DirectX 10 games, though shades of its capabilities are visible in current games like *Oblivion*, *GRAW* and *HL2:Ep1*.

GTX/XTX: Means nothing! NVIDIA has been using this handle since the past year to refer to their top of the line graphics cards—for example, the 7900GTX and 8800GTX. ATI does the same thing with 'XTX', the XTs big brother—literally. As of now only two cards bear this 'top-end' label—The X1900XTX and the X1950XTX.

Unified Shaders: Think of these as the Turbocharged V8s of the graphics world. The latest generation cards sport shader units that can perform pixel and vertex operations as required, as opposed to separate pixel and vertex shaders on previous generation cards. Strength in numbers comes to mind when you're thinking Shaders.

GDDR4: Graphics Double Data Rate Four memory takes over from GDDR3, with a serious increase in clock speeds. GDDR4 memory has crossed the two-gigahertz barrier.

Crossfire: We aren't talking about getting caught in one! CF refers to ATI's equivalent of NVIDIA's SLI (pronounced sly), which basically means harnessing the processing power of two graphics cards to nearly double performance.

Usage: My X1950XTXs in *Crossfire*, with *GDDR4* show great *HDR*, but now I want the *8800GTX* for *Unified Shaders*.

Wild Wild Web

The Spirit Of Web 2.0

If you're in the market for a Web host and need some refreshing honesty, nouptime.com is the place to go. The site has a graph on the main page, titled Average Monthly Downtime. It is ascending.

In keeping with their policy and central philosophy: "We are constantly working to improve our server downtime." And just why should you use their services? 200 KB of storage, FTP via floppies mailed to them, and the best we found was Ajax E-mail: "In

the true spirit of Web 2.0, everyone is invited to read and edit your emails."

Taking the cake is one of their customer "testimonials": "Exceptional service for an exceptional price. My only complaint is that technical support told me to f*** off when I called them, but everything else has been great." Not so funny, actually, considering it happens.

How Do These Things Happen?

Well, how do they? At commerce.computa-

center.com, you might just stumble upon the stock-phrased "too good to be true" offer: Italy bundled with a computer. Here's one configuration we found:

- Micro Tower - P4 640 3.2 GHz
- RAM 512 MB - HD 1 x 40 GB
- CD-RW / DVD-ROM combo
- Win XP Pro - Monitor: none
- Italy

That's exactly what it reads. Neatly bulleted. Even though the boo-boo has been spotted and reported, Computacenter refuses to back down on its offer. Go figure. Warranty not clear, though.

online interface."

Surely you're going, "What the...?"—They're dumbing down *phishing*, too? While phishers everywhere spend precious time engineering the most devious schemes, this tool comes and pollutes the good, pure principle of the thing by giving even the average Joe the power to wreak his own financial havoc. When there's no respect (even if reluctant) for the efforts of true-blue phishers, we wonder—what is the world coming to?

According to the analysts at RSA Security, there are two primary advantages to this kit. Quoting from their site:

"1. It is a "universal" phishing kit, meaning it can easily be configured per target. Fraudsters who want to initiate a phishing attack do not have to purchase or prepare a custom phishing kit for each target. Once they acquire and operate this kit, the attack can be configured to "import" pages from any target website.

"2. Unlike standard phishing attacks, which only collect specific requested data (typically login and card-related credentials), this attack is designed to intercept any type of credentials submitted to the site after the victim has logged into his account as well."

All this means that not

only will script kiddies be able to carry out their own phishing attacks, they might even be able to do it better! Be afraid. Be very afraid. Michael Sutton, security evangelist at SPI Dynamics has some great advice, though: "In order to defend against man-in-the-middle attacks, users should avoid clicking on links in e-mail messages," he warns. Heartening.

UNLEASH THE HOUNDS

Attack Of The Crazy Fruit

Ah, Apple. No company can ever compete with its brilliant product design, quality of service, or skills at harassing anyone with even a thought of crossing their path. The iPhone released at MacWorld this month (count the number of times we've mentioned the iPhone and e-mail it in for a special reply!), and expectedly stunned the hoi polloi with its keypad-less design. Everyone wants one now, and while they wait for their savings to accumulate, Windows Mobile users could download a skin for their phones so they would look like iPhones.

No points for guessing that Apple threw a hissy-fit—these were copyrighted icons and designs that were being used without permission, and hence an infringement on their rights. A tad extreme, even for Apple, but we can see their position—we'd have concerns if any of you lot decided to run around with notebooks carrying the *Digit* logo, too. But here's the best part—not only did the Big Fruit run around demanding the skin be taken down, they even served legal notices to bloggers who reported its existence! The content of the message goes thus:

"It has come to our attention that you have posted a screenshot of Apple's iPhone and links that facilitate the installation of that screenshot on a PocketPC device.

"While we appreciate your interest in the iPhone, the icons and screenshot displayed on your website are copyrighted by Apple.

"Apple therefore demands that you remove this screenshot from your website and refrain from facilitating the further dissemination of Apple's copyrighted material by removing the link to <http://forum.xda-developers.com>, where said icons and screenshot are being distributed."